DIVISION BELLS

ANTI-CAA AGITATION, 2020

Assam, Delhi

46TH ANNIVERSARY
YOUTH UPRISINGS

The massive protests against the CAA erupted first in Assam before spreading to other northeastern states

In December 2019, the Union government passed the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), which enables Hindu, Sikh, Jain, Parsi, Buddhist, and Christian illegal immigrants from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan, who have entered India on or before December 31, 2014, to apply for Indian citizenship. Massive and partly violent protests erupted first in Assam, led by the All Assam Students' Union, and soon spread to other neighbouring northeastern states. In Assam, police firing claimed five young lives.

Protesters in the Northeast feared that providing citizenship to illegal immigrants from Bangladesh would alter the region's demographic balance, resulting in a loss of their political rights, culture and resources. Meanwhile, on December 15, major protests took place near the Jamia Millia Islamia in Delhi where mobs burnt and destroyed public property. The police forcibly entered the Jamia campus, used batons and tear gas, injuring over 100 students. In protest against the CAA and in solidarity with Jamia students, civil society groups and students took to the streets in many parts of India. However, unlike the protesters in the northeast, their counterparts elsewhere believed the CAA to be discriminatory against Muslims. Following the Jamia violence, Muslim men and women began a peaceful sit-in protest in Delhi's Shaheen Bagh from December 15, 2019. The protests continued till March 2020, when the Covid pandemic struck. ■

– Kaushik Deka

TWO SIDES OF THE CAA COIN **While protesters in Northeast feared the law would alter the region's demographic balance, those in Delhi and other states felt it was discriminatory against Muslims**

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



▼ A candlelight march against the CAA from Jamia to Shaheen Bagh in New Delhi, January 3, 2021